leaders and their constituents, who often see autonomous IOs as encroachments on national self-determination. This perceived detachment can exacerbate populist opposition and diminish trust in IOs, particularly if member states feel sidelined from key decisions affecting their interests.

Finally, unchecked autonomy can lead to accusations of inefficiency or corruption, further undermining an IO's legitimacy. Without clear mechanisms for accountability, autonomous IOs risk alienating the very states and stakeholders they aim to serve. Weighing the benefits of autonomy with the need for member engagement and transparency is thus critical for ensuring that IOs remain effective, credible, and resilient in the face of populist pressures. In navigating these trade-offs, IOs must tread carefully to preserve their independence while maintaining the trust and cooperation of their member states and the broader public.

9.3.4 Transparency

We have identified secrecy as a potent mechanism enabling IOs to engage constructively with populists while allowing populists to avoid domestic backlash. Secrecy measures thus serve as a strategic tool to mitigate populist resistance, offering significant advantages. Indeed, many IOs already operate covertly in certain areas, capitalizing on the benefits secrecy can provide. Yet its overuse or mismanagement can lead to negative repercussions.

In terms of benefits, secrecy enhances international cooperation in critical ways. It allows IOs to secure sensitive information, as demonstrated by the UN Security Council, where classified discussions about conflict zones protect lives and preserve fragile peace processes. It also fosters open and candid dialogue by providing a confidential space for member states to voice concerns, negotiate disputes, and explore compromises that might be politically untenable in public settings. For example, the WTO's private negotiation mechanisms encourage forthright communication, helping to resolve disputes without the pressures of public scrutiny (Kucik and Pelc 2016). Additionally, secrecy shields IOs from premature media sensationalism and public backlash, which can derail delicate negotiations or generate misunderstandings. In peace talks or complex global initiatives,